

Loyalty and Disloyalty

Basic of Loyalty

1. The Importance of Loyalty (Why Loyalty)

1.1 Loyalty is the principal qualification for every minister.

- You are not qualified for the ministry because of how gifted you are!
- Faithful and loyal people in church are most qualified to be leaders. Bible teaches us that the cardinal requirement for leadership is faithfulness and not anything else. "...it is required in stewards, that a man be found faithful. (loyal, constant, dedicated, devoted, trustworthy and dependable)" (1 Corinthians 4:2).

1.2 To fight the fifth column

- Satan often does not have the occasion to launch deadly attacks against the church from outside; hence, he has to use someone from within. In the case of Jesus it was a traitor (Judas) whom Satan used.

The Fifth Column

An army general surrounded a large city with the aim of conquering it. This city was heavily fortified with a high and imposing wall and gate. The army general surrounded the city in readiness to attack. One friend of the general came along and asked him, "Sir, how do you think you are going to overcome the defenses of this city? No one in recent history has been able to conquer this great city." The army general smiled and said, "It's my fifth column. I'm depending on them to do the trick." The general's friend was very interested and asked, "What is this fifth column? I thought you only had four columns." The army general replied, "I do have a fifth column."..... My 5th column consists of my spies, agents, friends and supporters who are already within the city. You just wait. They will open those big gates from within and my armies will rush in."

- The only way the enemy can destroy a successful and powerful ministry that is doing all the right things is to fight it from within. The 5th column comprises the disloyal, double-faced, double-tongued and discontented people within the ministry. If these people are allowed to wreak havoc as they so very well can, they will destroy the church.

- If we want to have a large church, we need to walk in love and with oneness. If you cannot be one with the church, stop pretending. We encourage people to walk out of our church if their hearts are not with us. He that is not with *us* is against *us*... Matthew 12:30.

1.3 For the love of God to fill the church

- The ministry is supposed to operate with the power of love, unity and teamwork.
- People are attracted by love. When they see us as church members/leaders flowing together in genuine love they are attracted.
- Whenever there is treachery and distrust the church people become scared and wary and stay away.

1.4 To have a large and successful ministerial team

- For the ministry to extend and bear much fruit there must be team work.
- However, it would be better to work alone than with a team of disloyal, disgruntled, disunited and disaffected people. In fact, it is not possible to have an effective team with such people.
- Loyalty is important to build united successful ministerial teams (e.g. Youth, Worship team, Sunday School and Mother' structures, etc.).

2. Aim(s) of Teaching Loyalty

- **Establishing a culture of loyalty within church. All church members must be loyal to the church/pastor at all levels.**
- In a culture of loyalty it's unacceptable to speak negatively about any church member or pastor.

3. How to Develop a Culture of Loyalty

- **The key of the north wind (Proverbs 25:23).**
 - Powerful rainstorm is driven away by a strong wind. In the same way, the power of malicious backbiting tongues can be neutralized by certain facial expressions.
 - Show a disloyal person by your face that you are not interested in their conversation. Your disagreeable attitude is strong enough to deter unruly and rebellious elements. People will gradually get to know that disloyal people are not welcome in the church.
 - Loyal member must learn to drive away any **backbiting and criticism of the pastor.**

- **The key of constant pruning.**
 - People who don't want to be with you us (HMC) must go; and they must leave as soon as possible. It's as simple as that.
- **The key of teaching against disloyalty.**
 - Most people are ignorant of the evolvement of the disloyalty process. In other words, many rebels are unaware of what they are doing.
 - No one is born with faithfulness and loyalty written all over him or her. Every church member will have his/her due share of temptations to become disloyal. **Thank God, You Can Be Taught To Be Loyal.**

4. Stages of Disloyalty

Disloyalty doesn't just happen overnight. Becoming disloyal is a process! Most people are unaware of the fact that they are becoming disloyal.

Importance of knowing stages of disloyalty; first of all, it will help you to identify and kill any such tendency within you. Secondly, it will help you to detect disloyalty in any person you work with.

4.1 First stage -- the independent spirit

- The independent stage is so subtle that most people do not recognize it for what it actually is – disloyalty.
- When a church member develops an independent attitude, he/she becomes autonomous within the church. The rules of the organization no longer control him/her.
- For instance, the pastor may say, "We are all fasting on Friday." But the person with an independent spirit would think, "I've already decided to fast on Wednesday. So that's what I'll do."
- A member with an independent spirit decides to attend only those meetings (services, prayers, outreaches, pulpit shift, council meetings, etc) he/she feels are important. Such a person obeys only certain instructions - the ones he/she thinks are really important. This person is independently doing exactly what they think should be done!
- There is nothing wrong with being independent. However, if you are a part of HMC you are not independent. When you begin to exhibit a spirit of independence within the church, be it known to you that you are becoming disloyal.
- If you're an HMC member, you are not independent of HMC. Therefore, you cannot just do what you think is right. You must comply with directives that are

coming from the head. **If you feel you want to be independent then you should resign.**

- **An Analysis of Joab's Independent Spirit**

- The first example of the independence of Joab was in the murder of Abner (2 Samuel 3:20-27).

When the King opted for peace with Abner, his right-hand- man (Joab) decided to do otherwise. Although he was supposed to submit to the wishes of the king, he went ahead with his own plan.

- The second incident was in Joab's handling of Absalom's coup d'état. And the king commanded Joab... Deal gently for my sake with... Absalom..."(2 Samuel 18:5)

There was an unnamed person who was part of King David's set-up and was obviously loyal to him (Samuel 18:12), and refused to kill Absalom as per the king's command. But Joab (David's right-hand man) a man with an independent spirit act contrary to the king's command (2 Samuel 18:14).

Independent people do what they want to do inspite of the instructions that are emanating from above.

- The third example of Joab's independence was when he fought against the royal city of Rabbah on behalf of King David.

When victory was in sight he sent a warning message, "You better come and participate in the war otherwise I will get all the credit... (2 Samuel 12:28). He wanted David to be there himself! What he was saying in other words was, I'm no fool to do all the hard work only for you to take the glory.

- The fourth example of Joab's independent spirit comes at the end of king David's life.

David made it very clear that he wanted Solomon to be the next king. There was another son named Adonijah who wanted to be king in the stead of Solomon. To do this he needed the help of some perfidious characters. Once again Joab, who knew David's wishes, went contrary to it and helped Adonijah (1 Kings 1:5, 7).

4.2 Second stage – passivity

- When a member is in the passive stage of the disloyalty process he does not involve himself in much. He sits and watches unconcerned and uninvolved.
- Passivity builds from the spirit of independence, because members in this stage of disloyalty have “you don’t own me anymore” type of spirit.
- Other church members become passive because of disciplinary measures taken against them. Other causes of passivity: hatred, bitterness, forgiveness, etc.
- Passive members don't get involved in church activities. They say things like, "I don't want any more trouble in this church. Let me just keep to myself.
- “Cursed be he that doeth the work of the Lord deceitfully, and cursed be he that keepeth back his sword from blood” (Jeremiah 48:10). This verse is actually teaching us that it is a curse to be uninvolved when you have something to pitch in. God expects you to get involve and to contribute.
- Passivity is dangerous because you move rapidly into the critical stage of disloyalty. In order to become critical you must be uninvolved. You must have enough time to scrutinize and despise the church and its leaders.
- Absalom was doubtlessly angry with Amnon for raping his sister Tamar, but said nothing for two whole years. That is passivity! Doing nothing and saying nothing!“And Absalom spake unto his brother Amnon neither good nor bad” Notice that Absalom quickly degenerated into a murderer and tergiversator when the opportunity presented itself (2 Samuel 13:22, 28).

4.3 Third stage - the critical stage

- A disloyal member is not passive forever; he progresses into the next step of being critical.
- This is the stage of noticing and magnifying faults. In church, he finds faults with the preaching of the Word and with the order of service.
- Miriam had become critical of Moses. She had followed his leadership all the way out of Egypt, but now she began to see his faults and humanness. And she spoke about his marital problems. “And Miriam and Aaron spake against Moses” (Numbers 12:1).

4.4 Fourth - the political stage

- When a member becomes political, he tries to involve others in his ideas and philosophies.
- When a church member is becoming disloyal he tries to involve other members in his treacherous ideas. He wants to gather a following and make people believe that he has identified a real problem that must be addressed. This is exactly what Absalom did.
- **Three Favourite Phrases of Disloyal People at the Political Stage**

When a person is in the political stage of disloyalty, he has three favourite phrases:

- A lot of people are saying "so-and-so".
- Everybody is saying "so-and-so".
- Many people are saying "so-and-so".

4.5 Fifth stage – deception

- It's of surety that people who rebel are grossly deceived.
- Common deceptions that members encounter as they progress along the road of disloyalty:
 - **Despising Pastors:** Members despise their pastors just because they have acquired a little success. E.g. bought a new car. You must remember that you have been helped by somebody to get to where you are. You must never forget that, in a certain sense, you have been set where you are by or through someone else.
 - **The Deception of Apparent Success:** "Thine heart was lifted up because of thy beauty..." (Ezekiel 28:17). Apparent success in your calling, career, business, etc. transforms you into a rebel. No one can control or counsel you anymore. Members in this state have cutting rebukes for their seniors, pointing out to them that they are not always right.

4.6 Sixth stage - open rebellion

- This is the stage where deceived rebels fight openly against authority.
- A member in this stage of disloyalty gains psychological support by gaining the support of some of the people he talked to. Remember that Lucifer gained the support of over a third of the angels.
- Rebellion is an essentially evil thing; its evil like witchcraft (1 Samuel 15:23).
- Examples of open rebellion:
 - **Lucifer did this.** "And there was war in heaven ...and the dragon [the devil] fought" (Revelation 12:7). Amazing how Lucifer rebelled without any offence!
 - **Absalom fought against his father (2 Samuel 16:11).**
 - **Absalom tried to become his father in all aspects, including in the bedroom (2 Samuel 16:22).**
 - **Judas betrayed and fought against his Lord and master (Matthew 26:47, 48).** Jesus never offended Judas but yet he rebelled!

4.7 Seventh stage – execution

- The Bible teaches us that rebellion is as witchcraft (1 Samuel 15:23), and the biblical punishment for witchcraft is execution. "Thou shalt not suffer a witch to live" (Exodus 22:18).

- It is a known fact that the rebels of the Bible did not end up well. The end of all rebels is one and the same – execution.
 - **Lucifer:** “And the great dragon was cast out, that old serpent, called the Devil, and Satan, which deceiveth the whole world: he was cast out into the earth, and his angels were cast out with him” (Revelation 12:9).
 - **Absalom:** “And ten young men... compassed about and smote Absalom, and slew him” (2 Samuel 18:15).
 - **Judas:** “And he (Judas)...went and hanged himself” (Matthew 27:5).
- The people who get involved in revolts are often simpleminded. Many of them do not know what is afoot. “And with Absalom went two hundred men out of Jerusalem, that were called; and they went in their simplicity, and they knew not anything” (2 Samuel 15:1).

5. Lessons on Loyalty

5.1 Loyalty demands full persuasion.

- Paul was accused of been a ringleader of a sect and the source of mischief (Acts 24:5, 6), hence, anyone working with Paul would have to be fully persuaded about his character (2 Timothy 1:12).
- It is important to establish in your heart all the facts about the ministry or person with whom you're working. Be fully persuaded so that when the accusations, trials and testings come you will be able to remain faithful.

5.2 Your loyalty must be to the higher authority.

- The church as different authorities, some have a higher rank than others. The lesson here is - if the question of loyalty arises, your loyalty as a church member must go to the higher authority.
- A member who is not under authority does not have authority. The right standing of a member with the church is accessed by his/her submission to the head pastor.

5.3 A loyal person does not withhold information.

- A loyal person is open to his senior about whatever is going on.
- “It is reported commonly that there is fornication among you...” (1 Corinthians 5:1). Notice that Paul did not have a word of knowledge about the extent of immorality going on in the church. Someone reported it to him.
- “For it hath been declared unto me of you.... By which are of the house of Chloe, that there are contentions...” (1 Corinthians 1:11). This kind of reporting leads to the edification of the church.

- **NB.** There's a difference between godly reporting to the appropriate authorities and slanderous gossip.
- When you know of something evil, you are expected to tell it!
- "...Bigthan and Teresh..... sought to lay hand on the king Ahasuerus. And the thing was known to Mordecai, who told it" (Esther 2:21, 22).

5.4 Loyalty is based on principles and not emotions.

- Decisions based on emotions rather than principles are not substantial.
- When you decide to belong to HMC, you must make your decision based on principles and not on feelings.
- Loyalty is broken when the Word and its principles are set aside.

5.5 Loyalty will cost you relationships and friendships.

- To be loyal to someone means you cannot be loyal to everyone. Your loyalty to Christ means that you cannot maintain some of your old friendships.
- **Loyalty Is Expensive:** *"...whosoever therefore will be a friend of the world is the enemy of God" (James 4:4). Anyone who is the friend of the church's enemy is also an enemy of the church.*
- Friendship with this means enmity with that! Your commitment to a cause may even cost you your relationship with your family (Luke 14:26).

6. Signs of Disloyalty

6.1 A member who disappoints you in times of pressure or crisis.

- Watch out for members who are absent during hard times. It is in times of pressure that you see the true character of a person.
- Why did Paul say he wouldn't work with Rev. John Mark? It was because John Mark had deserted him in a time of crisis. "But Paul thought not good to take him [John Mark] with them, who departed [deserted] from them..." (Acts 15:38).

6.2 Members who disappoint when they are under pressure.

- There are some people who often present themselves with problems concerning homes and families. Have you noticed that these problems have not prevented them from going about their jobs?
- Any member who deserts the church when he is under pressure is a potentially dangerous person.

6.3 Members who think that they can do what the pastor is doing better than he/she.

- Anyone who is watching senior pastor/pastor, and has thoughts flashing through his/her mind - "I could do this better" or "If I had the chance, I would also be able to minister like that, and probably even better"- is a dangerous person to have around. (Absalom's example, 2 Samuel 15:4).

- Note: A person is not doing what he is doing because he is the best at doing it. He is doing it because God has put him there.

6.4 Any member who is prepared to attack his own father or senior in ministry.

6.5 Wounded members who have never recovered from their hurts.

- Two types of members. One type recovers from the offence and moves ahead with his life. The other type seems to harbour some lingering unforgiveness, and these become potential defectors.

6.6 Members who are not prepared to be trained or re-trained in the ministry.

6.7 Members who are not prepared to do menial jobs.

- Anyone who is not prepared to do menial jobs may be too lofty for real ministry.
- The disciples did menial jobs. They were ushers, waiters, errand boys, and scavengers.
- Philip the evangelist who was first sent to work in the church cafeteria. When he was asked to sort out all the problems of the church in relation to food, he did not say that it was below his dignity. He did not even mention that he was called to be an evangelist!

6.8 Members who are irritated and reactionary every time the pastor correct them

6.9 A member who gives excuses and continually justifies himself.

- Members who constantly deny any wrongdoing. It seems they are never wrong about anything. They never have anything to apologize about.

6.10 A member who does not keep promises.

6.11 A member who is vying for promotion and recognition.

- "Adonijah... exalted himself, saying, I will be king..." (1 Kings 1:5). Adonijah was position conscious. Although he was a prince, he wanted to be king himself.
- Many members have the position but do not do the job. As leader/member you must do the job that goes with your position.

6.12 A member who has never been criticized.

- A member who has never been criticized is often surprised when his superiors are under attack.
- A member who has been through the fire of criticism is different from someone who has never been criticized.

6.13 A member who does not say amen or smile whilst the pastor is preaching.

- Any loyal member will appreciate the sermons of his pastor. His support of the pastor is demonstrated when he constantly vocalizes his agreement by saying "Amen".
- You cannot say that the expression on your face and your silence mean nothing. Silence means something. And the expression on your face means something.

- Because God knows that a person's facial expression means something, he advised Ezekiel and Jeremiah not to be frightened by people's facial expressions. "Be not afraid of their faces..." (Jeremiah 1:8).

6.14 A member who does not take notes when the pastor is preaching.

- Members who do not take notes whilst the pastor is teaching think that they know everything.
- He may be saying, "I'm as good as the pastor. And there is nothing new that the pastor can teach me!"
- John the Apostle could not minister effectively to Diotrephes because he felt too big (pre-eminence) to receive from John (3 John 9).

6.15 A member who does not pay tithes and offerings.

- Anyone who benefits from the church, but secretly does not support it, needs to be watched. He is a disguised robber and traitor.

6.16 Members who do not attend certain meetings.

- **Most definitely, the absence of certain members from some meetings will cause them to be different from loyal members. Attendance at all important meetings is essential to maintaining loyalty.**

6.17A member who approves of someone who makes wrong decisions.

6.18 Members who are not prepared to do things they did not choose to do.

- Members must be prepared to do what they are told to do - it's required of you to obey instructions.

6.19 A member who poisons you about others.

- Any member who poisons your mind about other people is a dangerous person. Never forget that "He that speaks negatively about somebody to you will speak negatively about you to somebody."
- Learn that a person who spews out negative things about others is a devil. That's what the Bible says!

6.20 A member who is not prepared to be birthed into the philosophy, the standards, the vision, the procedures and the spirit of the house.

6.21A member who does not stay around to mingle and interact with other church members.

6.22 A member who thinks too much money is being spent on the head.

- Usually, a trait of disloyalty manifests itself when other loyal members begin to appreciate the pastor. Often this is out of guilty feelings that the disloyal leader may have, since he does not get involved whenever there is a show of appreciation for the pastor.
- Judas, like all disloyal people, felt it was a waste to spend such an amount of money on the pastor (John 12:5).

6.23 A member who is always late for meetings.

- Lateness is a reflection of the unwillingness of the person to be a part of the meeting.

6.24 A member who does not contribute to a joint effort which is intended to bless and appreciate their pastor.

7. Loyal Leaders / Members

A leader is anyone operating in any of the following positions: elder, deacon, structure committee, ministry (cluster) committee, minister (preaching/music), etc. **NB: This does not mean members not serving in such positions are not leaders. Every member is a leader, just different roles.**

A GOOD AMBASSADOR

A good leader/member can be compared to a good ambassador. He does not reflect his own ideas and visions, but only those of his home country (senior minister). He does not only obey instructions, but he also genuinely support and flow with the head or senior pastor.

- Make mention of your senior pastor often, and in a favourable light.
- Quote your pastor as often as possible.
- Genuinely admire your pastor and praise him/her often.
- Introduce your pastor in an exciting way and make positive or complimentary remarks about everything that he/she has preached.
- Acknowledge you're pastor's presence.
- You must find genuine excuses for any lapses in the head.
 - Everybody makes mistakes, and nobody is always right. So your senior will have his/her fair share of mistakes. It is your duty as a good assistant to defend and protect the developing ministry of your pastor.
- **Always remind the congregation that you are not the main pastor.**
- Be genuinely happy at the promotion of your pastor.
- Ensure that everything is well with your head pastor.
- Honour your pastor's wife as well. Minister to her and give her gifts.
- Acquire your pastor's tapes.
- In your preaching, do not hesitate to refer to your pastor as an example of a successful person.
- Flow with decisions and policies made by the pastor. **Do this even if you have a different opinion.**

- A good leader/member does not establish a private, side-fellowship in the church without the knowledge or approval of his pastor.
- A loyal leader/member takes notes at meetings whilst his senior pastor is talking or ministering.
 - It's a mark of humility: It means that someone senior or someone with more insight than you is imparting knowledge to you. If leaders write notes, it will encourage all the others to do the same.
- A loyal leader/member personally gives gifts to his senior pastor.
- A loyal leader/member is protective of his senior pastor. He is prepared to defend against any problems arising out of his pastor's mistakes.
- A good leader/member is not ignorant of the fact that his pastor is human and capable of making mistakes.
 - A good leader/member does not think that his Head is infallible. He knows that his pastor can and does make some mistakes. **This is why he prays so hard for him.**
- A good leader is content to be an assistant.
 - A good leader is happy to stay in his position.
 - A content leader does not covet his pastor's position or anything that is his pastor's

8. Disloyal Leaders / Members

The Characteristics of Disloyal Leaders / Members

The following are signs to identify disloyal behaviour. As Leaders or members you can identify any of these traits to also judge yourselves.

- When things go wrong unfaithful leaders/members are quick to say, "i knew all along that this would not work."
- When the pastor comes up with a suggestion, new idea or vision they have no comment to make - neither good nor bad.
 - Silence, especially in time of trouble is often indicative of someone who is not in full agreement.
- A treacherous leader/member will eagerly look for opportunities to sit in his pastor's chair.
- The bad leader/member sees all the faults and mistakes in the senior pastor's life. He rarely sees any good thing.
- The disloyal leader/member notices the good attributes of external ministers, but never speaks positively about his own pastor.

- A subversive leader/member constantly listens to tapes from external ministers and learns from them. But he never listens to his own head pastor's tapes.
- A disloyal leader/member is a habitual and persistent receiver of complaints.
- They do not clap, smile, say "amen", shout, or laugh when the head is preaching.
- A disloyal leader/member does not sing, or lift up his hands during worship. Neither does he clap his hands during praise.
- A bad leader/member is not happy at the wealth and blessings of his senior pastor.
 - Disloyal leader/member feel that they do the "donkey work" while the pastor reaps all the rewards.
- A disloyal leader/member openly disagrees with his head pastor.
- The disloyal leader/member considers the privileges and honour bestowed upon his pastor as uncalled-for and wasteful.
- Disaffected leader/member does not make any "extra" effort!
- A disloyal leader/member fights the people the head pastor has appointed.

The declarations of treacherous men

These are the sayings coming from the lips of disloyal people....

- Some of us could be head pastors. It is just that we have decided to submit.
- I would like you to pray with me about certain things that are going on at the office - the way I am being treated.
- I will not come. I will not go. I will not be transferred.
 - Remember that during the rebellion of Korah, Dathan and Abiram refused to come when Moses called for them (Numbers 16:12).
- You are proud and difficult to work with. You are stubborn.
 - A disloyal leader/member he sees the strength and firmness of his pastor as stubbornness and pride.
- When pastor is away the church grows and many more people attend the services.

Disloyal Leaders / Members: Those Who Pretend

- The words of his mouth were smoother than butter, but war was in his heart: his words were softer than oil, yet were they drawn swords" (Psalm 55:21). Ahithophel was at war with David, but the words of his mouth did not reveal it.
- There are people who blow both hot and cold air. They produce bitter and sweet waters at the same time. "From the same mouth come both blessing and cursing. My brethren, these things ought not to be this way. Does a fountain

send out from the same opening both fresh and bitter water?" (James 3:10-11 NASB).

- Some leaders/members are perfect pretenders. They pretend to love the pastor, but their hearts are full of hatred.

The spirit of the scoffer

- Mockery is a spirit that tries to shut people up and intimidate them
- Sanballat and Tobiah made fun of Nehemiah's attempt to rebuild the wall. They said that if even a fox climbed on the wall they were building it would break it down (Nehemiah 4:1-3).
- When somebody has the spirit of a scoffer, he sees all your weaknesses and faults.
- The spirit of the scoffer tries to stop the church in all its endeavours: Scoffers come to prevent the pastor from going ahead with the vision that God has given him/her. .
- There is also a group of mockers who say little or nothing to the pastor, these are silent scoffers. You must understand that their silence may mean that they despise the pastor and would not even bother to relate or communicate with him/her.

9. Avoiding Disloyalty

Admitting that you did something wrong is not the same as repentance. Following seven points would help to differentiate between a forced admission of wrongdoing and true godly repentance.

- First of all, admit to yourself and to God that you have been a rebel.
- Ask God for His mercy and forgiveness.
- Confess your rebellion to those against whom you rebelled.
- Tell your rebel group that you have realized that you were a rebel. Explain to them your decision to repent.
- Go to the church from which you rebelled and confess your sins publicly.
- Confess to any other parties that were involved during the time of your rebellion.
- Those from whom you rebelled will forgive you for your rebellion and release you in God's blessing.

10. Laws and Statutes of Loyalty

- Loyalty is the key to expansion.
- A leader breeds loyalty in his followers by being loyal to his superiors.
- A leader breeds loyalty by being loyal to God.

- Solomon experienced disloyalty when he turned to serve other gods (1 Kings 11:4-9).
- **Loyalty demands the right attitude.**
 - There are some attitudes that do not lead to loyalty. A suspicious person cannot be a loyal person. If you suspect the pastor of wrongdoing, how can you be loyal to him/her?
- **Loyalty does not join or create factions.**
 - One of the works of the flesh you must avoid is creating factions and groupings within a united body (Galatians 5:19- 21 NIV).
- **The root of disloyalty is pride.**
 - "ONLY BY PRIDE cometh contention" (Proverbs 13:10).
 - You only rebel against a person when you think you are 'as good as' he.
 - Korah's group told Moses, "Why do you make yourself different from us?" They felt that Moses should be equal to them. This is the spirit of an equalizer (Numbers 16:3).
 - Watch out for these symptoms of pride: (a) Answering back. (b) General rudeness. (c) Refusing to come when called. (d) Feeling indispensable. (e) Mocking and laughing at leaders. (f) Feeling that I am as good as my senior. (g) Constant criticism.
- **Loyalty is an integral part of character.**
 - Loyalty is not simply a set of rules you must obey. It is a matter of developing an invisible quality, a certain style and character of doing things.
 - Loyalty must emanate from the heart. It must not just be the following of instructions.
 - Disloyalty is an integral part of a person's character and culture. Because of this it takes time for a person to imbibe and assimilate the philosophy, tradition and culture of loyalty. However, when it is established it yields wonderful fruits.
- **Familiarity breeds disloyalty.**

To be familiar means to be more friendly and informal than is acceptable. It is condition that develops between you and someone you know well, see often and hear often.

 - **When a person is often seen and heard, he is usually taken for granted:**

That is why guest ministers are often appreciated more than the local pastors. This should not be the case! A local pastor often does more to make a church successful than the visitor does. Visiting ministers are

often seen as heroes. The reason for this is because of the lack of familiarity.

- **Familiarity leads to a loss of respect and reverence:** With time, this can progress into disloyalty. When Jesus came on the scene, he was not received in his hometown because the people were too familiar with Him. They asked one another, "Is that not the carpenter's son?"

Familiarity breeds contempt, which can lead to disloyalty. Miriam and Aaron spoke against Moses because of the Ethiopian woman whom he had married. And they said, Hath the Lord indeed spoken only by Moses? hath he not spoken also by us? Miriam was Moses' sister. She probably knew him very well. She was a relative and knew all about his weaknesses. Aaron was also someone who was very close to Moses. It seems that they took this closeness for granted. A disloyal person often finds faults and criticizes his leaders. That is exactly what Miriam and Aaron did!

- **Familiarity makes you forget important spiritual principles:** Be careful when you speak against God's anointed servant. When you see him through the eyes of familiarity, you may think that he is a mere man. You will forget all that the Lord has accomplished through him. This will make you lose your reverence and you may walk into error.
 - **Familiarity has a way of breaking down reverence, respect and fear:** Once these natural barriers are removed, acts of disloyalty happen more easily. After the judgment had come on Miriam (Numbers 12:10, 11), Aaron realized that they had been foolish to think that they could correct Moses. What people don't realize is that no human being can really correct a man of God. It is God who called them and it is God who will judge them. If you do not agree with or believe in a man of God, just move away quietly and leave him to the Lord.
- **Statutes of loyalty.**
 - **No matter what you do, some people will be disloyal:** No matter what you do, some people will become disloyal in the process of time - so pray that it will not be you! Work on yourself so that you do not fall prey to the deceptions that lead to disloyalty.
 - **Teaching on loyalty must be remembered in the hour of temptation:** Peter made a profound declaration of commitment to the Lord (Luke 22:31-34). But when it really mattered, Peter forgot all the things he had said. Like with all temptations, it is important to remember the things we

have learnt when it really matters. Be careful to remember your commitment in the hour of temptation.

- **A loyal person does not destroy what he builds.**
 - “For if I build again the things which I destroyed, I make myself a transgressor” (Galatians 2:18).
 - Choose whether you are a builder or destroyer and stay within your calling.
 - Do not break down somebody's house in order to build yours. You will only reap what you sow!
 - Do not break down the church in order to advance your own agenda. How do you destroy a church? With your mouth of course! Let us choose whether we are building or destroying.

11. The Rewards of Loyalty

“Well done, thou good and faithful servant: thou hast been faithful over a few things. I will make thee ruler over many things: enter thou into the joy of the Lord” (Matthew 25:21). This Scripture outlines three important blessings that follow loyal or faithful people.

1. Loyalty is rewarded with growth:

- Loyal people receive an increase (many things) from the Lord. The blessing of largeness is reserved for faithful and loyal people.

2. Loyal people experience the favour of God.

- The second blessing of faithfulness is entering the joy of the Lord. This means experiencing the favour of God.
- When the favour of God is upon you, your enemies will not flourish around you. “By this I know that thou favourest me, because mine enemy doth not triumph over me” (Psalm 41:11).

3. Loyal people see God's promises.

- The Joshua generation are the generation who put away complaining and grumbling. The Promised Land will be inherited by the generation that stops murmuring. If you can stop all forms of murmuring and grumbling in the church, you will see God's promise for your life.

Be a loyal person so that you can have great growth in your calling. Be a loyal person so that you can have God's favour over all that you set your hand to do. May you one day hear those coveted words, "Well done, good and faithful (loyal) servant." May you experience the good fruits and benefits that belong to every faithful Christian!

Causes and Timing of Disloyalty

Four Common Causes of Disloyalty

1. Offence.

- “And then shall many be offended, and shall betray one another, and shall hate one another” (Matthew 24:10). From this Scripture you can see that people begin to betray and hate one another when they are offended.
- **E.g. Absalom was offended by the rape of his sister Tamar by his half-brother Amnon. Gehazi got offended by Elisah’s refusal to accept an offering from Naaman (2 kings 5:20).**
- Church members get offended by the sermons their pastors preach. Bear in mind that no member is allowed to criticize his/her pastor’s message and speak negatively about the sermon. E.g. the member would say, the pastor was preaching about me! The only time a church members is allowed to question the pastor’s sermon is when he/she seeks clarity in order to better understand the pastor’s sermon (this must be done humbly and with good motives).
- Once a church member is offended by his/her pastor’ sermons, he/she starts to bring factions and strive within the church. They start to spread a bad report within the church, saying, “The pastor is preaching about me”.
- Other members get offended by disciplinary measure taken against them.

2. An erratic personality.

- There are some people who have a disposition to make sudden decisions. They can alter the plan of their lives within minutes. They can change their entire course within seconds. This is a very dangerous trait.
- Such people can be with you today but can desert you tomorrow.
- A Christian must be a person who makes a statement and sticks to his word no matter what it costs. “...He that sweareth to his own hurt, and changeth not” (Psalm 15:4).

3. Financial reasons.

- The next cause of disloyalty has financial roots. “For the love of money is THE ROOT OF ALL EVIL: which while some coveted after, they have erred from the faith, and pierced themselves through with many sorrows” (1 Timothy 6:10). The love of money is the root of all evil.
- Certainly, one of the evils that is stirred up by the love of money is disloyalty and rebellion. There are two categories of problems that arise from financial roots: **Financial Misunderstanding and Financial Covetousness.**

- **Financial Misunderstanding.**

Many of the rebellions in denominations are over issues of salaries, conditions of services, emoluments and benefits. Many Christians serve the Lord perfectly, but they seem to change when financial issues come up.

- **Financial Covetousness.**

When we speak about covetousness I am not talking about people who are in need. In this case, we are dealing with people who want more, more and more! The Bible teaches that people who love money are not satisfied with more money. "He that loveth silver shall not be satisfied with silver..." (Ecclesiastes 5:10). Apostle Peter warned against people who enter the ministry for the love of money.

- **The ministry is the wrong profession if all you want is to acquire wealth:** If you love money, please stay in the secular world and earn all you can. When you come into the ministry, your aim must be to make full proof of your calling. God's ministry is not a business so please do not turn it into one.
- **The ministry of the Lord Jesus is not the place to make money:** Neither is it the time of your life to gather wealth. I am not saying that you should be poor! God will bless you with all you need so that you can serve him, but this will be at the right time!
- **Examples of covetous pastors:** (1) Gehazi was the associate pastor of Elisha who could not resist the temptation of using the ministry as a business. He wanted to charge money for the gift of God. He was charging for prophecies and healings. Does that sound familiar?

(2) Judas Iscariot sold his master for only thirty pieces of silver. And said unto them, what will ye give me, and I will deliver him unto you? And they covenanted with him for thirty pieces of silver" (Matthew 26:15). Rev. Dr. Judas Iscariot lost his life and ministry because of greed and covetousness. Thirty pieces of silver is all that it took to make him sacrifice his friend, his master and his God.

If you're a Judas or a Gehazi in the church, you will never be satisfied with what your pastor offers you. You will always think that your pastor is cheating you.

4. **Missing God's direction.**

The fourth common cause of disloyalty is missing God's direction for your life. Many people miss God's direction for their lives. Because of this, they end up in complicated situations.

- **Sometimes people are often forced into disloyalty by their own mistakes.**
 - **A common trick of people who go their own way is to claim that God has sent them** (i.e. claim they were led by the Spirit of God!).
- **Many people become rebels and disloyal to their pastors because of their disloyal friends.** Don't think you will be loyal to your church/pastor while you still maintain friendship with people who are disloyal to the church/pastor. Law of Association.
- **Yielding to the pressure of the people.** Some people will pressurise/entice you to join their rebellious scheme, don't yield to their pressure.

The Timing of Disloyalty

Disloyalty includes a whole array of things. These range from subtle acts of disloyalty to betrayals, insurgencies and open rebellions. But, when do these things happen? Do they happen all the time? Or do they have specific seasons and timings?

1. **Disloyalty occurs with the apparent weakening of a leader.**

- **All leaders go through different phases of their lives and ministries:**
 - In the prime of their ministry, they often appear very strong, hard, tireless and invincible. Leaders may appear to weaken in the latter part of their ministries.
 - This apparent weakening of a minister is not actually a diminishing of his strength. Sometimes in later years, the maturing minister speaks with a softer tone and is more accommodating. Sometimes it is a result of entering into another phase of ministry.
 - In the early part of Jesus' ministry, He was very strong on certain things. He was a strong direct preacher. He was a no-nonsense personality. He was confrontational preacher.
 - When Jesus entered a different phase of His ministry (sorrow of death), Judas misinterpreted this to be a weakening of His master's anointing. Judas was encouraged to rise up and rebel against the Lord when he heard him speak of dying.
 - Don't rebel against your pastor thinking his/her power had diminished. Power has in no way diminished; he/she has entered a different phase of ministry.

2. Disloyalty occurs with the aging of the leader.

- In the life of King David, it was when he was very old and stricken in years that Adonijah rebelled against his father. Adonijah was one of David's sons who had been a loyal member of the family for many years. "Now king DAVID WAS OLD and stricken in years..... THEN ADONIJAH THE SON OF HAGGITH EXALTED HIMSELF, saying, I will be king: and he prepared him chariots and horsemen, and fifty men to run before him" (1 Kings 1:1, 5).

3. Disloyalty occurs when the leader falls short.

- Some church members become disloyal when their leader falls short. This is wrong and should be avoided. Consider David, he served Saul even after he fell from grace!

4. Disloyalty occurs upon the death of a leader.

- Many churches disintegrate after the death of their founders and leaders. Why does this happen? Disloyal people are often looking for an opportunity to break away or revolt against authority.
- Often the death of a leader signifies to them the removal of a factor that has long prevented them from rebelling.
- Rebellious people sense a weakening in the system by the passing away of the leader.
- Ahab, the king of Israel, was a wicked but strong ruler. He had the Moabites under control. But when he died, Moab rebelled almost immediately. "And Mesha king of Moab was a sheep master, and rendered unto the king of Israel a hundred thousand lambs, and an hundred thousand rams with the wool. But it came to pass, WHEN AHAB WAS DEAD, THAT THE KING OF MOAB REBELLED against the king of Israel" (2 Kings 3:4, 5).

Are you a rebel at heart? Will your loyalty persist even when there is an apparent weakening of the leader? Will age, sin or even death of your leader turn you into rebel? TIME WILL TELL

Advanced Doctrine of Loyalty

1. Doubtful Men

- Doubtful person is someone whose loyalty comes into question from time to time. At times, the person may seem very loyal and at other times, disloyal.

- At times, they exhibit much loyalty and faithfulness and at other times, they are disloyal.
- They may side with the church or they may turn against the church depending on the issue at hand.

2. Dangerous Sons

2.1. Signs of dangerous sons.

- **A dangerous son is full of unforgiveness and bitterness.**
 - Absalom did not forgive his brother for raping Tamar. He nursed the hatred in his heart for two years. He planned his revenge and eventually carried it out.
 - This world is a place of much offence. Many things will offend you in the church. Harboursing bitterness is the last thing that a church member should do.
- **Dangerous sons attack their brothers.**
 - “Now Absalom had commanded his servants, saying, Mark ye now when Amnon's heart is merry with wine, and when I say unto you, Smite Amnon; then kill him, fear not: have not I commanded you? Be courageous and be valiant” (2 Samuel 13:28).
 - Attacking and killing your own brother is a very bad sign and a cause for concern.
 - **Dangerous sons are not changed by years of hardship and difficulty.**
 - Watch out for church members who had to be disciplined and corrected. The fact that they have been through punishment does not mean that they have repented.
 - The spirit of Absalom is not corrected through punishment and even years of hard discipline. Do not be deceived into thinking that Absalom has changed just because he has been through a period of discipline, hardships or even poverty.
- **Dangerous sons feel that they cannot be dismissed.**
 - Whenever a person feels indispensable he is a dangerous person to have around. Some people feel that they are untouchable and can never be dispensed with.
 - As soon as you begin to think of yourself as indispensable, you are becoming proud and deceived. There lot of people who can serve God better than you. You're dispensable!
 - Sometimes, people sense that they are special and loved and they take advantage of this special place that they have. That is also a mistake.

There is always a Joab that will do the job that the father doesn't want to do.

- **Dangerous sons think they can replace their pastors.**
 - **Dangerous sons** desire to take over and **replace** his pastors. They think they are good as their pastors (2 Samuel 15:3-4).
- **Dangerous sons criticize their pastor.**
 - Absalom criticized his father's way of governing the country. Criticism is born of an evil spirit. There is simply nothing that justifies criticism. All of Scripture condemns this practice.
 - Dangerous sons criticize the way in which their pastor manages church affairs.
 - Any spiritual person will be hesitant to speak against God's anointed, no matter the reason. Miriam felt she had a good reason to speak against Moses. When she criticized him she was struck with leprosy (Numbers 12:8-10).
 - **Ham, The Dangerous Son:** Ham found out that his father was drunk and decided to tell others about it. He scoffed at his own father! What Ham forgot was that if Noah had not built an ark, he would not even exist! Do not criticize your father even if he is drunk. Pray for yourself that you will never have the same drinking problem!
- **Dangerous sons influence others against their pastors.**
 - Watch out for people who campaign against their pastor, trying to make you turn against your own pastor.
 - Don't be easily influenced like those simple minded people who followed Absalom (2 Samuel 15:11).
- **A dangerous son steals the heart of the people from his pastor.**
 - "And on this manner did Absalom to all Israel that came to the king for judgment: so ABSALOM STOLE THE HEARTS of the men of Israel" (2 Samuel 15:6-13).
 - Disloyal sons turn the hearts of church members against their pastors.
- **A dangerous son wants the pleasures and privileges of his pastor.**
 - "So they spread Absalom a tent upon the top of the house; and Absalom went in unto his father's concubines in the sight of all Israel" (2 Samuel 16:22).
 - The privileges of a pastor are special. It is important to respect the privilege that God has given to pastors.

- **Dangerous sons have destructive tendencies.**
 - You can see the ruthlessness in Absalom by this act of burning Joab's farm (2 Samuel 14:29-30).
 - A ruthless person is a dangerous person. In their quest for power or attention, they will do anything. **They do not mind burning down the entire ministry or the reputation of their pastors in order to get their way.**
- **Dangerous sons are men of conspiracies, secret meetings and side discussions.**
 - “And Absalom sent for Ahithophel the Gilonite, David's counsellor, from his city, even from Giloh, while he offered sacrifices. AND THE CONSPIRACY WAS STRONG; for the people increased continually with Absalom” (2 Samuel 15:12).
 - Dangerous sons are people who have meetings after the official meeting, discussions on the side and private jokes, which no one else understands. These are all signs that there is hidden information which is being kept from the pastor.

2.2. Dangerous sons lack the ability to induce loyalty in their followers.

- Dangerous sons are doomed to failure in life or ministry because they have been castrated of the power to induce loyalty.
- The testicles of loyalty have been removed and therefore there are no more seeds that generate loyal followers.
- After leading armies of people to kill your own pastor, how will you be established as a pastor? The very foundation of loyalty and commitment is destroyed.

3. Reaping the harvest of disloyalty

- **Removing Foundations**
 - You cannot build on foundations that you have destroyed. If you are disloyal to your pastor, your followers will also be disloyal to you.
- **Doomed to Reap a Harvest**
 - Disloyal people are doomed to reap what they have sown (Galatians 6:7). “For they have sown the wind, and they shall REAP THE WHIRLWIND” (Hosea 8:7).
 - In the case of Absalom, he reaped what he had sown almost immediately; he chose a disloyal person as his chief counsellor.